

8.4 Workshop: Cutouts and the Vector Mask

If your aim is mainly to cut objects out of their background, you can also use the Vector Mask. It works much in the same way as the Layer Mask, only instead of drawing or painting onto the mask, we will use the Pen tool to draw a *vector*, which can be resized and reshaped as and when we feel like it. (More information on vectors and the Pen tool later).

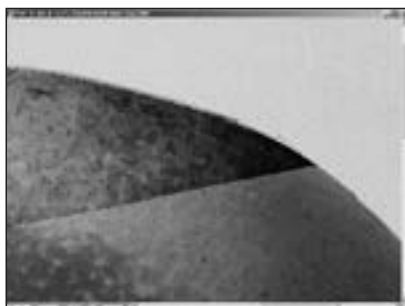
Step I: Beginning

We'll use the same fruit image as we did for the previous workshop. Duplicate the Background layer in the Layers palette and apply a filter to it—any filter will do; we're just using it to verify the effectiveness of the mask. We chose the Fresco effect from the Artistic filters (Filter > Artistic > Fresco).

We will start by creating a new hide-all vector mask from the Layer menu: Layer > Vector Mask > Hide All.

Step II: The vector mask

You will need to zoom in really close for best results; select the Pen tool ([P])  from the toolbox and start with the cutout. To use the pen tool, click to create a *control point* and drag the mouse in the direction you want the curve to go. Keep repeating this along the edge of the fruit to see how it works. The direction of the curve can be controlled by adjusting the *control handles* at the control points (they look like dumbbells sticking out on either side of the control point). While you're drawing the curve, hold down [Ctrl] to switch to the Direct Selection Tool (a white mouse pointer). With this tool, you can now select and move the various control points as well as the control handles.



Look at the effect shine through